Bar Hebraeus — Ethicon (Book of Ethics)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Bar Hebraeus — Gregory Abul-Faraj (1226–1286), Maphrian of the Syriac Orthodox Church and, in the record's words, the last great Syriac polymath, a scholar whose learning ranged across many fields. His *Ethicon*, or Book of Ethics, is his great work of moral and ascetic theology, writing about how a person should live and about the disciplined practices of a religious life. English readers have known it only in pieces, in the chapters A. J. Wensinck carried into his *Book of the Dove* in 1919. The dedication honours Bar Hebraeus, and remembers Wensinck as the named predecessor whose partial translation any completion would openly continue.

The story

Bar Hebraeus — Gregory Abul-Faraj (1226–1286) — was Maphrian of the Syriac Orthodox Church, a senior office in that church, and he is described in the record as the last great Syriac polymath: a scholar whose learning ranged across many fields. His *Ethicon*, or Book of Ethics, is his great work of moral and ascetic theology — writing about how a person should live, and about the disciplined practices of a religious life.

The *Ethicon* reached English readers only in pieces, and the pieces arrived inside another book. In 1919, A. J. Wensinck published an English *Book of the Dove* at

Leiden, through Brill. Its full description, as recorded in the HathiTrust catalogue, is that it translates the *Dove* “together with some chapters from his Ethikon.” Some chapters — not the whole work. Wensinck's volume is in the public domain, and it is available in full view at HathiTrust, but what it gives of the *Ethicon* is excerpts.

That precise gap is the subject of this dossier. The *Dove* is available. Parts of the *Ethicon* are available, because Wensinck carried them with it. A complete English *Ethicon* was not found after research. The task that remains is therefore a completion in the strict sense: to translate what a named predecessor left out, and to join the new translation openly to his, so that readers can see which portion is his work and which portion is new.

The work and what survives

The source text is Bedjan's *Ethicon seu Moralia Gregorii Barhebraei*, published in Paris and Leipzig in 1898. Bedjan's edition prints both the *Ethicon* and the *Book of the Dove*, and it is in the public domain by date.

The surrounding works by Bar Hebraeus sort cleanly, and the distinctions matter. His *Ecclesiastical Chronicle* is closed as a candidate: Wilmshurst's complete English translation exists, published by Gorgias in 2016, and it is in copyright. Do not build on that work. The *Book of the Dove* is already in English in the public domain, in Wensinck's 1919 translation. *The Laughable Stories*, in Budge's 1897 translation, is in the public domain and is not a gap.

The *Chronography*, his secular history, stands in a more careful position. Budge's translation is dated 1932, and the record states that it is not safely public domain by United States publication date alone. Its renewal status needs a hardened check — a further, firmer check of the copyright record — before any reuse.

A second gap by the same author is recorded as a bonus finding. The *Book of Directions*, or *Nomocanon* — in Syriac, *Kethabha dhe-Hudhaye* — was published by Bedjan in Paris in 1898. A Latin version exists in Mai's *Scriptorum Veterum Nova Collectio*, volume X. No English was found in the searches run. As a work of church law, it fits the church-records interest of this collection, and it is a candidate for a second volume.

Its English fortunes

No complete English *Ethicon* found after research.

What exists in English is Wensinck's public-domain *Book of the Dove* of 1919, carrying some chapters of the *Ethicon* with it, as excerpts only.

What completing it would take

Completing it would take a translation of the *Ethicon* books and chapters that Wensinck omitted, made from Bedjan's 1898 Syriac text. The new translation would be keyed chapter by chapter to Wensinck, so that the public-domain portion of 1919 and the newly translated portion form one complete volume, honestly labelled as such. Wensinck is to be credited as the named predecessor — the scholar whose partial translation this completion continues.

Sources

- https://catalog.hathitrust.org/Record/000984438 (Wensinck 1919: *Dove* + "some chapters" of the *Ethicon*)
- https://studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/tce/b/bar-hebraeligus.html (Bedjan editions; Nomocanon)
- https://books.google.com/books?id=888GswEACAAJ (Wilmshurst 2016 — the closed gap)